Ban Treaty, the establishment of the "hotline" between the White House and the Kremlin.

"One of the ironic things," Kennedy observed to Norman Cousins in the spring of 1963, "…is that Mr. Khrushchev and I occupy approximately the same political positions inside our governments. He would like to prevent a nuclear war but is under severe pressure from his hard-line crowd, which interprets every move in that direction as appeasement. I've got similar problems…. The hard-liners in the Soviet Union and the United States feed on one another."[8]

Having stared down the nuclear abyss together, the two leaders were determined that the world would never again suffer such a crisis. As for the alleged Kennedy obsession with Fidel Castro, a year after the missile crisis Kennedy was exploring the possibility of normalizing relations with Castro's Cuba.

In November 1962, while the thirteen days were still fresh in his mind, Robert Kennedy dictated a memorandum to himself. "The 10 or 12 people who had participated in all these discussions," he said, "were bright and energetic people. We had perhaps amongst the most able in the country and if any one of half a dozen of them were President the world would have been very likely plunged into catastrophic war."[9]

It was a narrow escape from oblivion.

Arthur Schlesinger, Jr.
April 1999

NOTES

1. N. S. Khrushchev, *Khrushchev Remembers: The Last Testament* (Boston, 1974), 511.

2. Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., "Four Days with Fidel: A Havana Diary," *New York Review of Books*, 26 March 1992.

3. John F. Kennedy, review of *Deterrent or Defense* by B. H. Liddell Hart, *Saturday Review*, 3 September 1960. (The quote is from Liddell Hart.)

4. Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., Foreword to Pierre Salinger, *John F. Kennedy: Commander in Chief* (New York, 1997), vii–viii.